

Need For Speed Underground 2

NEED FOR SPEED Underground (NFSU) was a revolutionary game where you could mod almost every part of your ride. The game was a little monotonous because you just won a race, unlocked stuff, and went to the Customise menu over and over; NFSU2 throws in a whole city with five distinct parts that you have to unlock while following the storyline. You have the freedom to choose your race and sponsors, you've got three new modes, and many more cool features.

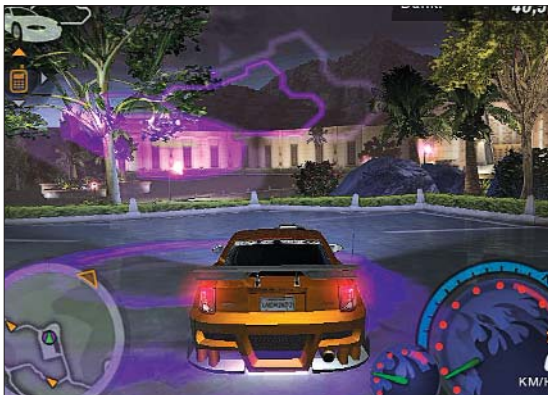
This is the first NFS game driven by a story. The story picks up from where NFSU ended, depicting you as a top-dog racer, when suddenly an idiot in his 4x4 smashes into your ride one night. Once you've recovered from the crash, Samantha (the girl in NFSU) directs you to Bayview, where you need to rise up back to the #1 position. Every few races, a cutscene is played, which leads to the next stage of the plot. The end objective is to find the person

who totalled your car and give him hell.

NFSU2 looks splendid, and the night-time races add to the effect. The game uses a tweaked NFSU engine. Motion blurs and light trails have been fine-tuned to perfection. The effects when you hit the nitrous give you a sense of speed hard to find in any other game. The cars are exact replicas of their real-world counterparts.

As for those oh-so-lame crash effects, the introduction of a

'different' camera angle still can't make them look any better. Due to the lack of damage modelling, the only enjoyment you can get is out of the nice sounds that shearing metal makes. Overall, the game isn't more graphically advanced than NFSU.



The night-time races in NFSU2 are really well done



The city is split into five parts that are unlocked in stages

Car In The Big City

The races in NFSU2 can be completed in any order. The city is split into five parts that are unlocked in stages. Also, instead of a one-stop modding menu, you need to visit shops scattered across the city. You need to unlock these shops by finding them, upon which they'll be added to your GPS map. Points where races will take place are also displayed on the map, but some races you'll have to uncover.

The tweaking in itself is pretty exciting. Almost every car part can be tweaked. Every fancy addition earns you respect, increasing the points you get as well the nitrous boost you have. Your tricked-out car will also get featured in magazines, earning you cash in the process.

Basically, the game revolves around you striking deals with sponsors and fulfilling your contract. Race modes consist of the legendary Drag, Circuit, Sprint and Drift races, with a notable addition being Street X, a combination of the Circuit and Drift modes. Then there's the Time Attack, where you have to complete certain objectives in the given time.

More Sound Than You Want To Handle

Snoop Dogg's remix of *Riders on the Storm* is the best opening sequence we've ever heard. The other tracks aren't that good, though. Effects such as engine sounds, crashes, nitrous boosts, and various other ambient sounds have been done extremely well.

Multiplayer in NFSU2 is as simple as it gets—all single-player modes are available in multiplayer. The servers are good—you can play online even with a slow Internet connection (we used a 33.6 Kbps modem).

The graphics are good, sound effects great, music OK, but the voice acting needs a lot of improvement. If you crave the need for speed this game is definitely for you—it's worth the money. Until the next iteration, satisfy your speed addiction through this game, not in the real world. Drive safe.

Need for Speed Underground 2

Publisher **Electronic Arts**

Developer **EA Canada**

Web site www.needforspeed.com

System requirements **933 MHz CPU, GeForce2, 256 MB RAM, 2 GB**

HDD space

Distributor **Gayatri Impex**

Price **Rs 1,299**

Courtesy SKOAR! Magazine